

BONELESS

by

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CAST OF CHARACTERS

GOBI (60s) is a veteran scientist and Marrow Designer. They worked on the first lab-grown meat (the 2013 London Burger) and struggles with the ethical implications of a "boneless" future that has forgotten its past.

JACA (20s) is Gobi's mentee and Marrow Designer who embraces the Great Peace brought by lab-grown meat and works to secure their father's right to clean air through career advancement.

CEO (V.O.) is the voice of the company behind Cloud Protein, who views Gobi's and Jaca's actions as potential liabilities or marketing gimmicks.

OTHER VOICE OVERS: Announcer, Gobi's Parent, Gobi's Mentor

BUTCHER is a traditional butcher in London who gives Gobi a photograph of a cow and shares a philosophy about valuing the weight of what you eat.

SETTINGS

Year: Mostly 2060s (Act III: Mostly 2013)

Laboratory, Park, Kitchen Arena, Orbital Garden in Space

NOTES

/ - interruptions or interjections

DAVID QUANG PHAM

David Quang Pham is an award-winning playwright and composer in New York. Originally from Michigan, they are recognized for creating works that personify science to explore the human condition and social issues. Their 2025 season includes the world premiere of *Turnover: A New Leaf* (Queer Theatre Kalamazoo) and *Chemicals in the Water* (The Tank), as well as the development of *The Living Fossils* (Workshop Theater, People's Theatre Playwrights Unit finalist). They are a 2026 Cinephilia fellow, 2024 Great Performances Fellowship Award recipient, 2021 Playwrights Foundation fellow, and 2020 Working Title Playwrights apprentice. Their work has been performed nationally and in Portugal. They hold a B.S. in astrophysics with honors and a minor in theatre from Michigan State University. Be up to lightspeed at [science.studio](https://www.science.studio) and [@sciencetheatre](https://www.instagram.com/sciencetheatre).

PROLOGUE: LAB-GROWN MEATSCENE 1

LABORATORY

2060. Afternoon.

The standard workspace hums with machinery. There are vats with lab-grown meat around.

60-something-year-old Gobi is supervising, a veteran scientist who has just taken on a new charge. Jaca is a 20-year-old bright, enthusiastic Marrow Designer intern, wearing a lab coat and safety goggles.

GOBI

Whopper? Do they still call it a whopper?

JACA

Do they still call you all boomers?

GOBI

I expect nothing more from a mindless intern.

JACA

Your mindless intern!

GOBI

You're dense.

JACA

The bovine density levels are stabilizing perfectly, Dr. Gobi! We're at 1.0. This procedure is ready to try during the Harvest. A perfect Harmonic Disc on the fiftieth try!

GOBI

The cells are finally... compliant.

JACA

Our blood cells no longer feel like jail cells. My father said the air on the ground used to hurt his lungs. I can't imagine a world like that.

GOBI

It was heavy. A different kind than this.

Gobi taps the glass of the vat.

GOBI (CONT'D)

We did a good thing, kid. We traded the slaughterhouse for the foundry. This... this was supposed to be the miracle.

JACA

And it is! "Mercy with Every Bite." Our CEO's favorite slogan. This will be the standard for the next harvest.

GOBI

(to themself)

Mercy is a heavy word with no backbone.

(to Jaca)

Just make sure you log the texture data correctly. They want to ensure it has no "Texture Aggression."

JACA

It'll be perfectly smooth. The algorithm guarantees a soft bite. No drama, just good tech and clear air. And a juicy chicken wing.

Jaca starts entering data. Gobi pauses for a moment, then reaches into their pocket and briefly touches a worn photograph of a cow in a field before returning to work. The hum of the machine continues.

Black out.

SCENE 2

PARK

2060. Morning.

A pristine park with lush trees. Jaca and Gobi are jogging at a moderate pace.

JACA

(Breathing heavily)

Air tastes good today.

GOBI

(Breathing harder)

It's... efficient.

JACA

You okay? That's barely a slope.

GOBI

The bones in my legs are not what they used to be. Lab-grown chicken wings... how about human legs?

JACA

The 2030s called. They want their lactic acid back. The rumor is they're close to a new regeneration protocol. A patch, maybe? Slap it on, no soreness, ready for tomorrow's run.

GOBI

A patch? Sounds like you're trying to engineer the satisfaction right out of the effort.

JACA

I heard they're even hoping to regrow a full arm with it someday. No more prosthetics. Just perfect, clean, new flesh. A miracle made real.

GOBI

A new arm. A new leg. A seamless, clean absence of trauma.

JACA

Exactly. My dad used to cough through half his day due to the polluted air. That was a liability. This air, this park... It's the Great Peace made real.

GOBI

There's a difference between not having to think about a cost, and forgetting it entirely. You forget the cost, you forget the value.

JACA

Anyway. We should pick up the pace. We're on the clock for the lab. The future waits for no one, you know.

GOBI

Let the future weigh on you.

JACA

I wonder when medicine will give us wings?

They jog off into the distance.
The hum of the nearby city
machinery is audible.

Black out.

END OF PROLOGUE

ACT I: THE CHICKEN WINGS PRELIMINARYSCENE 1

THE KITCHEN ARENA

June 21, 2063, almost noon.

We are at The Final Harvest, a global, live-streamed cooking competition, celebrating the 40th anniversary of lab-grown chicken wings. The mood is celebratory and optimistic.

On center stage is Bioreactor XY, a massive translucent cylinder with levers and a tablet. If all goes well, it would soon hold a chicken wing. Above is the Jumbotron, which flickers with corporate logos, view counts, updates on every contestant, and chicken memes.

Two pools of light on stage. On one side, 24-year-old Jaca is by the bioreactor. Nearby, 60-something-year-old Gobi meticulously polishes a set of holographic knives.

JACA

(to the audience)

They ask me why I want the Bio-License. They think it's about the money. But they don't see the air. By 2063, the Great Peace has been our finest achievement. The pastures are forests again. We've seen a seventy percent drop in methane emissions and a ninety percent reduction in water usage globally because we stopped mass livestock breeding. No one wakes up hungry. We traded the slaughterhouse for the foundry, and the Earth breathed back. We don't eat meat. We consume mercy. I am a Marrow Designer, the architect of the weightless feast. I'm going to grow a world where nothing ever has to die to be delicious. I am the future, and the future is perfectly, beautifully-

GOBI

(to the audience)

Spineless! They call it Cloud Protein. I call it memory loss. 2063 is a sponge, absorbing history and calling it "optimization." My mentee thinks they're designing a miracle. I'm just here to make sure the miracle has a backbone. Even if I have to break the machine to do it.

ANNOUNCER (V.O.)

Let us celebrate the Cloud Protein: a revolutionary, lab-grown meat alternative cultured from a single cell, requiring no traditional livestock farming! It's the present and future of guilt-free dining!

Music plays.

Lights go blinding neon. A massive bass drop shakes the room.

ANNOUNCER (V.O.)

Citizens! Welcome to the preliminaries of... The Harvest! Forty years ago, the lab-grown chicken wings ere born.

GOBI

Lab-grown abominations...

ANNOUNCER (V.O.)

Tonight, two generations unite or clash! Will the legacy hold, or will the cloud rise? Your sixty-minute wing assembly starts... now!

The Jumbotron timer snaps to 59:59. The light in the arena shifts to red. Jaca lunges for the terminal console. Gobi crawls out of the maintenance hatch, grease-stained and defiant.

JACA

Gobi! The Floor Manager is screaming! We're live! Why are you still in the hardware port?

GOBI

I'm busy reminding this biomass that it used to have an anatomy, Jaca.

JACA

Is that... is that a bone? Gobi! This is a televised arena!

(MORE)

JACA (CONT'D)

We're supposed to present the Meatless Wing. If the judges see structural debris on the primary scan-

GOBI

It's an avian rib. 2023 variant. I'm giving the viewers some history to chew on.

JACA

Darn dad jokes... Anywho, it's a design flaw! We're the Cloud Protein generation. If you put a hard object in that vat, you'll be the first contestant in history disqualified for aggressive Geometry. You'll snap the judges' veneers!

GOBI

Forty years ago, people liked the "fight" of a meal. Now, you're trying to win a license by serving meat with the personality of a wet napkin.

JACA

I have the official recipe-lock! We're supposed to be flushing the scaffold logic to make room for the 2013 London Burger finale. We're going Pure-Fluid, Gobi! That's how we win the license and get out of this foundry!

GOBI

The "Pure-Fluid" wing just failed, Jaca. I spiked the nutrient-mix with high-density calcium. It turned into a puddle of expensive gray soup at 0400 hours. The only thing in this building that stayed upright... was my bone.

A beat of pure terror.

JACA

You sabotaged our preliminary? On a global feed? Ten minutes ago you were my mentor. The one who was gonna perfect my legacy! Now look at you—you're a biological terrorist!

GOBI

I'm a cultivator. I'm forcing you to show the world a spine.

JACA

The sensors are already red-lining. The algorithm doesn't know how to map a solid, Gobi! It thinks the rib is a tumor. Look at the Cloud. It's shivering! It's trying to vomit the foundation back out of the nutrient mist.

GOBI

It's not shivering. It's breathing. It's forty years deep into a Meatless lie, Jaca. Let it be heavy for once. If the Cloud wants to be a wing, it has to learn how to wrap itself around the truth.

JACA

I have a mortgage in the Breathing Zones! My father's oxygen-debt is three months overdue. I don't have the luxury of "the truth." I just need the harvest to stay upright long enough to get us into the Golden Jubilee.

A low-frequency THUD vibrates the floorplates. On the Jumbotron, the density-graph spikes into the red. The timer reads 45:00.

ANNOUNCER (V.O.)

Forty-five minutes remaining! The 2023 wing is showing... Unexpected mass. Is this a leap forward, or a collapse in the making? Viewership has just cleared six billion!

JACA

(to the vat)

Stabilize! Damn you. If the acoustic fields invert now, this whole room becomes a pressure cooker. We'll be seared into the assembly before the judges even arrive!

GOBI

It won't. It's finally eating, Jaca. Look at the vascularity. It's threading through the calcium. It's... it's nostalgic.

JACA

It's a biohazard! The CEO is pinging my ocular feed right now. They're seeing the "Legacy" signature. They want a remote safety-purge before the drones lock on!

GOBI

Tell the CEO that if they cut the power, they're murdering the most "telegenic" harvest in history. Look at the metrics. They don't want a Meatless Wing. They want to see if the ghost can breathe.

The lights in the arena cycle through a rapid, clinical white. The Jumbotron snaps to a close-up of the vat.

The Cloud Protein is no longer a mist; it is a dense, throbbing amber mass, tightly bound to the avian rib.

ANNOUNCER (V.O.)

Thirty minutes remaining. Judges are hungry. Don't let the cloud collapse! The chicken wing is pulsing! We have a biometric signal! Is it alive, or is it... Lunch?

JACA

The density is at 1.4. It's over-calcifying, Gobi! The rib is acting as a heat-sink. If we don't bridge the thermal-regulator, the protein will sear from the inside out before the harvest-bell rings.

Gobi rips open a maintenance kit on the floor.

GOBI

Then we bridge it. Give me the sensors.

JACA

Gobi, if you link your pulse to that machine, you'll be blacklisted. You're throwing away forty years of "Clean" science. You'll never work in a bio-foundry again!

Gobi tapes the sensor to their arm.

GOBI

I'm not throwing it away, Jaca. I'm giving it a heartbeat. Look at the view-count. Six billion people aren't watching for the protein. They're watching to see if we bleed.

JACA

They're watching because they want to see us fail!

GOBI

No. They're watching because for the first time in their lives, they're looking at something that has a price.

Gobi offers the secondary patch.

GOBI (CONT'D)

Link in, Marrow Designer. Stop polishing the future and start holding the foundation.

Jaca looks at the patch, then at the glowing, shivering vat. With a jagged, desperate motion, they rip open their sleeve and slap the sensor onto their forearm. A resonant THUD vibrates the floorplates as the two heartbeats synchronize. The vat flares with a brilliant, unified gold.

JACA

It's... it's softer.

GOBI

Look at the Cloud. It's finally... raining.

Jaca is frantically swiping a holographic interface, attempting to override Gobi's manual calcium injection. Gobi stands guard over the maintenance hatch, arms crossed, blocking the thermal sensors.

The golden light from the Bioreactor begins to bleed into the clinical white of the kitchen. Jaca is still tethered to the console, their breathing synchronized with the pulsing meat.

JACA

(to the vat)

Steady. Twenty-five minutes until the judges sink their teeth into a moral dilemma. The density is stable at 1.0. Perfect. Absolutely perfect.

GOBI

(placing their head on the vat)

It feels like a drum solo. I can taste the difference already. It's got... conviction. It's not just growing anymore, Jaca. It's striving.

Jaca checks the haptic feedback.

JACA

The Ruby rib is becoming a heat-sink. It's pulling the excess thermal energy from your link. You aren't just giving it a pulse, Gobi; you're giving it an oven.

GOBI

It's the first time in my life I've felt the "cost" you keep talking about. It's not a line on a spreadsheet. It's a literal burn in my arm.

A beat.

GOBI (CONT'D)

Do you think they'll know? When they bite?

JACA

The tongue doesn't lie. You can code the texture, but you can't simulate the resistance. They'll feel the 2023 approval date. They'll feel the day the cages opened. They'll feel... us.

A sudden, violent glitch on the overhead screens. The logo of the Bio-Foundry flickers, replaced by a wall of scrolling red text:
"PROTOCOL BREACH. UNAUTHORIZED BIOMETRIC LINK."

GOBI

The CEO is trying to initiate a remote "Safety Purge." They're claiming the EKG link is a contamination of the product. They're trying to dump the vat before we hit the twenty-minute mark!

JACA

Let them try. I've slaved the acoustic levitation to our shared pulse. If they purge the vat, they purge our signal. We'll flatline on a global feed.

GOBI

You're holding the broadcast hostage.

JACA

I'm ensuring the harvest.

Gobi's fingers become a blur on the holographic keys. They are no longer a "Marrow Designer" following a recipe; they are a hacker rewriting the future.

GOBI

I'm overriding the Foundry's outbound data. I'm slaving the EKG monitor to the main Jumbotron.

(MORE)

GOBI (CONT'D)

If he wants to see who's in this room, I'm going to show him.

The overhead monitors snap into a thumping EKG display. Two hearts, one rhythm. The holographic audience in the rafters goes silent for a split second, then erupts.

ANNOUNCER (V.O.)

Whoa! A last-minute swap of the visuals! It seems our contestants are offering up a... Biometric experience! Twenty minutes remaining! The kitchen is heating up! The judges are ready to mingle with the meat!

JACA

Look at the pings, Gobi. They don't want the "Meatless Wing." They want the heartbeat.

GOBI

Then let's give them the Ruby.

The kitchen is no longer a room; it is an echoing chamber of red-lining alarms and the frantic, rhythmic thumping of the Jumbotron EKG.

JACA

The density... it's hitting 1.5. Gobi, the protein is becoming too rigid. If it hits 1.6, the Ruby rib will shatter. We'll be serving the judges a mouthful of calcified shrapnel.

GOBI

I'm dropping the acoustic pressure! I'm trying to soften the binding, but the CEO's override is still tugging at the valve! He wants it to shatter! He wants to prove that "Bones" are a safety hazard so he can bury the Legacy department once and for all.

ANNOUNCER (V.O.)

Fifteen minutes remaining! The heartbeat is steady, but is the wing? We're seeing structural stress! The cloud is fighting the foundation!

JACA

They don't understand... that you can't have a harvest... without a risk.

(MORE)

JACA (CONT'D)

Gobi, look at the marbling. It's perfect. It's the 2023 spec. If we can just hold it for fifteen more minutes...

GOBI

Jaca, your arrhythmia is showing on the main screen. The audience is starting to ping the "S.O.S." icons. They think you're actually dying for a wing.

JACA

Aren't we all? Every meal is a trade, Marrow Designer. I'm just... making the exchange... visible.

Gobi reaches for the manual
override lever.

GOBI

Not like this. I'm not letting you become the "Blood" in the "No-Kill" narrative. I'm slaving the thermal regulation to the arena's cooling system. I'm going to vent the excess heat into the rafters.

JACA

You'll set off the fire suppression! The foam will kill the vat!

GOBI

Then we better hope the judges like their wings
"Extra Crispy."

Gobi pulls the lever. A massive
hiss of steam erupts from the base
of the bioreactor. The golden
light in the vat flares into a
brilliant, blinding white.

ANNOUNCER (V.O.)

Whoa! A steam-veil! The contestants are pushing
the limits of the precipitation kitchen! Ten
minutes to harvest!

The timer hits 09:59. The steam
begins to dissipate, revealing
JACA and GOBI as two soot-streaked
shadows. The Cloud Protein inside
the vat has undergone a
transformation; it is no longer
shimmering—it is seared. A deep,
savory brown, with the iridescent
Ruby rib glowing like an ember at
its core.

JACA

(Coughing, eyes watering from the ozone)

Did it... did it hold?

Gobi checks the vibrating tablet.

GOBI

Density: 1.0. Moisture: 72%. It's... it's a perfect recreation. August 2023. The month we stopped being predators. The CEO just cut the remote override. The metrics were too high. They're pretending the "Steam-Veil" was an intentional marketing gimmick.

JACA

Of course they are. They're sell the "Pulse" as a premium seasoning.

ANNOUNCER (V.O.)

Five minutes to harvest! The chicken wing is complete! The judges are approaching the tasting podium! Citizens, prepare your palates for the first bone in a generation!

Gobi picks up a sterile carving blade and offers it to Jaca.

GOBI

You should do it. You're the one who remembers how to follow a spine.

JACA

No. You're the one who's gonna have to live in this world. You do the cut. I'll just... hold the plate.

Gobi takes a deep breath and steps at the vat.

GOBI

Thirty seconds to release. Jaca... if they hate it? If they say the bone is "primitive"?

JACA

Then at least they'll know they're still alive enough to be offended.

The timer hits 00:00. A orchestral chime. Hissssssss. The Chicken Wing settles onto the obsidian pedestal. It is solid, smoking, and undeniably heavy.

Gobi makes the first cut as silhouettes of judges descend into a tight circle.

ANNOUNCER (V.O.)

Harvest complete! Fifty million calorie-credits on the line! Judges, commence the sensory audit.

Jaca and Gobi stand back as silhouettes descend. They analyze. They strip the Cloud from the bone. On the Jumbotron, Jaca's heart rate is still visible, as a jagged line.

GOBI

Look at Judge 2. The Serotonin levels are flat. They're flagging the bone as Foreign Object Contamination" We're losing the point-spread, Jaca.

JACA

They don't know how to chew it. They're looking for the Cloud and they found... resistance.

On the screen, "PENALTY" flashes:
"TEXTURE AGGRESSION: -15 POINTS.

GOBI

We're in the red. Jaca, if we drop three more points, the CEO initiates the sunset clause. We're purged before the commercials hit.

ANNOUNCER (V.O.)

Is this meat? Or is this art? You decide!

JACA

Switch the feed. Now.

GOBI

Jaca, if I show them the EKG raw-data—

JACA

Show them the beat! If they won't vote for the meat, make them vote for our heart.

Gobi swipes a desperate command. The Jumbotron snaps from the seared wing to a close-up of Jaca's pale, sweat-streaked face and the frantic, syncopated rhythm of the two hearts. The holographic crowd in the rafters goes silent.

The Sympathy Meter begins to crawl upward.

ANNOUNCER (V.O.)

Wait... Look at the sacrifice! The marrow designers are giving their own biometrics to hold the foundation! The public vote is spiking!

An agonizing silence. The judges consult. The tally board flickers. A flickering gold light appears next to their names.

ANNOUNCER (V.O.)

By a margin of 0.03 percent... Jaca and Gobi advance! It is the narrowest win in the history of the Final Harvest!

The arena erupts, but the sound is hollow. Gobi collapses into a chair. Jaca remains tethered to the vat, staring at the chicken wing. It looks like the last thing to survive a nuclear war.

JACA

We didn't win, Gobi. We just bought six weeks of life.

The 2063 Golden Jubilee of the 2013 London Burger countdown shows up on the Jumbotron.

The tablet receives a ping.

GOBI

The CEO just sent a ping. "Congratulations on the performance. Don't let the Burger kill you. It's bad for the brand."

JACA

Forty-five days. Next time, the bone won't be enough. We're gonna need a miracle.

Black out.

SCENE 2

THE KITCHEN ARENA

June 21, 2063, evening.

The main arena lights are off. Only a few service lights illuminate Jaca and Gobi, who look exhausted. The Jumbotron above flickers silently with corporate logos. Gobi is polishing a set of holographic knives again. Jaca wipes down a stainless steel counter.

JACA

Consume mercy... Gobi?

GOBI

Mhmm.

JACA

Do you actually believe that?

GOBI

Believe what?

JACA

That we consume... *mercy*. That this... this whole operation is about mercy.

Gobi holds a knife up to the light, inspecting it.

GOBI

It started that way. Forty years ago. The first lab-grown wing was a promise. A promise we kept.

JACA

And now?

GOBI

Now it's a brand. Look at that ads. "Boneless." "Mercy with Every Bite." They want the feeling, Jaca, but they don't want the memory of its risks.

JACA

The risks were pretty high, Gobi. My father's oxygen-debt... the air back then... it was a relief when the pastures became forests again.

GOBI

A relief is not a virtue. It's an absence. We don't eat meat. We consume an absence of guilt. There's a difference.

JACA

Does it matter, as long as it feeds everyone?

GOBI

Yes.

Gobi places the knives in their case. The Jumbotron changes to a close-up of a smiling CEO.

GOBI (CONT'D (CONT'D)

Because if you don't know what you've lost, you can't value what you have.

JACA

Maybe valuing it means leaving the pain behind.

GOBI

Pain is the only thing that makes it real.

Jaca stops wiping the counter and slaps Gobi with a towel.

JACA

Too real.

Black out.

SCENE 3

THE KITCHEN ARENA

June 22, 2063, early morning.

The arena is dark and silent, save for the hum of the Bioreactor XY. Jaca is slumped against the console, asleep. Gobi is sitting on the floor, back against the console, a small, worn photograph in their hand.

GOBI

You know, I once saw a cow.

Jaca stirs, not fully awake.

JACA

A... a real one?

GOBI

Before the Great Peace. They were in a field, just... chewing grass. They had a heartbeat.

JACA

And?

GOBI

I had a burger that night. A real one. It was... heavy. And when I ate it, I just kept thinking about that thud in the field. I couldn't stop thinking about it. The smell of the grill, the juice... it all just felt like a lie. A beautiful, delicious lie that was built on a terror.

JACA

So you built this world to forget that feeling.

GOBI

I built this world so no one else had to feel it. But I didn't realize... we'd forget the animal entirely. The bone is my penance, Jaca. It's the memory I have to chew on.

JACA

Your dad jokes... My father has an oxygen debt. Three months overdue. He can't afford the clear air in the Highland Zones. He breathes... a discount atmosphere. This license buys him life, gobi. It buys him the right to breathe without a corporate tether attached to his-

GOBI

...leash? I know that. I'm just trying to make sure the life we buy... the life he breathes... is worth it.

JACA

He just needs the harvest to stay upright long enough to get us into the Golden Jubilee.

GOBI

Then let's make sure it's a harvest with a spine.

Gobi puts the photo away and stands up, stretching. Jaca rubs their eyes, looking at the sleeping vat.

Black out.

SCENE 3

BOARDROOM

A sterile, minimalist boardroom. A long, white table. Jaca and Gobi are seated on one side. Gobi looks exhausted. Jaca is wired and excited. A large, silent Jumbotron flickers with generic corporate logos. An intercom system sits on the table.

JACA

The CEO wanted a meeting! A meeting in the actual boardroom! This is huge, Gobi!

GOBI

It's a butcher's shop...

JACA

What? Anywho, it means we're official. We're part of the legacy.

A speaker crackles to life.

CEO (V.O.)

Jaca, Gobi. Congratulations. The metrics are phenomenal. A record six billion viewers. Your effect is called a "culinary leap forward" by the press. Pure theatre.

GOBI

(Muttering)

It was a structural stress test, not theater. We almost blew the vat.

CEO (V.O.)

An acceptable risk. You presented the public with something they didn't know they wanted: a spectacle. You made the process visible. Brilliant marketing.

JACA

The public vote is spiking because they saw the sacrifice, the biometrics. They saw us give the Cloud Protein a heartbeat.

CEO (V.O.)

The public saw passionate designers testing our tech for the brand. That's the story, Jaca. No "heartbeat". We don't need the public to assume you're essential to the product. The system is seamless.

GOBI

A seamless system is a lie.

CEO (V.O.)

A lie provides security. A lie ensures the Great Peace. We don't need the memory of the struggle, Gobi. We need the absence of guilt. That's the brand: "Boneless."

GOBI

Mercy is a heavy word with no backbone. You want the feeling of peace, but you don't want the memory of the risk.

CEO (V.O.)

The risk is a liability, Doctor. Your antiquated methods, this obsession with the past... it's a danger to the entire operation. We promoted you to the Orbital Garden to get you out of the main facility. Consider this a final warning: ensure the harvest in the Garden is silent. Clean. Pure-Fluid.

JACA

But the public liked the pulse... The beat...

CEO (V.O.)

The public likes a good story, Jaca. We write the script. Don't mess it up with sentimentality. Don't dwell on past beefs.

The Jumbotron suddenly changes from the corporate logo to a text: "OXYGEN AUDIT APPROVED. FINANCIAL DEBT CLEARED."

CEO (V.O.)

Now, if you'll excuse me, the Wild Ministers are expecting a briefing on Cloud Protein Optimization. Jaca, your father's oxygen audit was approved this morning. Congratulations.

The speaker cuts out abruptly. Gobi and Jaca sit in silence for a beat. Jaca stares at the screen.

JACA

They're terrified the world will find out that the meat still needs a person.

GOBI

Then we'll make them hear the beat.

Black out.

SCENE 4

APARTMENT

August 2033. Evening.

The apartment is small, but tidy. A TV flickers with a news report about global food security. A small table is set for one.

The only character on stage is YOUNG GOBI, who enters the apartment, looking exhausted and stressed. They drop their bag on a small counter, a small, worn photograph sticking out of a pocket.

PARENT (V.O.)

Late again, Gobi. Thought you were bringing the main course. The miracle.

YOUNG GOBI

Yeah. Chicken wing traffic.

PARENT (V.O.)

It's a miracle all the same. The Wing. Imagine, honey, clean air for the grandkids. No more filters!

GOBI crosses to the small counter, avoiding the table.

PARENT (V.O.)

Says here they're expecting a seventy percent drop in methane emissions in ten years! And water usage! Your work, Gobi. Your work is saving the planet.

YOUNG GOBI

Just a lot of numbers.

PARENT (V.O.)

It's more than numbers. It's security. For us. For your future. No more stress about the price of meat.

Gobi digs a hand into their pocket, fingers touching the edge of a photograph.

YOUNG GOBI

I saw a cow today. A real one. Just like this picture.

PARENT (V.O.)

A cow? What on earth for? That's the old world, son. The mess. The terror. We're moving past that. They're roaming where we don't need to.

PARENT (V.O.)

Is everything alright at the lab? Your mentor isn't pushing you too hard, are they?

YOUNG GOBI

No. Everything's great. The cells are... compliant.

Gobi picks up a fork from the counter and mimes poking at a plate, with a look of unease.

PARENT (V.O.)

Good. Because this license is our ticket, Gobi. This is it. The big break. Don't mess it up with sentimentality. Don't dwell on past beefs.

Gobi looks from the plate to the photo in their pocket.

Black out.

END OF ACT I

ACT II: THE LIMINAL MARROWSCENE 1

OBSERVATION DECK / SHIP

July 2063. Weeks after the Wing Preliminary

A high-speed mag-lev observation deck. Outside the panoramic windows, the Earth is vibrant—lush green corridors of re-wilded forests stretching where pastures once stood. The sky is a clear, crystalline blue. The high-tech thrum of Act I has been replaced by the near-silent whisper of magnetic rails.

A split stage with two spotlights. Jaca stands, arranging a digital herbarium of culinary plants on a tablet. Gobi sits, looking out the window. A glowing umbilical wire leads from Gobi's sleeve into a portable battery pack nestled in a duffel bag.

JACA

(to the audience)

We didn't just save the air... we saved the silence. Look at the horizon. Those forests used to be dust and bone. We traded the slaughterhouse for the foundry, and the Earth breathed back. But a world without hunger is a world that forgets. We've grown the "Cloud," but we've lost the weight of the story. I'm not just a Marrow Designer; I'm a librarian of the tongue. I'm trying to make sure that when we eat, we still remember the ground.

GOBI

(to the audience)

They call it the Great Peace. A world where no creature has to die for a feast. It's a miracle I spent thirty years building. But a miracle without friction is just a dream. Jaca thinks we're going to the Orbital Garden to win a prize. We're going there to prove that Kind Meat can have a soul. The 2013 London Burger ain't a product.

(MORE)

GOBI (CONT'D)

It is however a handshake between our technology and our ancestors. Look at me be a conductor today.

The two spotlights merge as Jaca joins Gobi at the window.

JACA

The CEO didn't evict us, Gobi. They promoted us. The 2023 Wing was a hit. They want the Golden Burger to be the centerpiece of the New Era. They want the world to see that the Cloud has a backbone.

GOBI

They want the backbone, Jaca, but they're still terrified of the bone. They want the beauty of the forest without the memory of the struggle.

JACA

They want stability. My father needs stability. His oxygen-audit was approved this morning because of our metrics. For the first time in his life, he isn't breathing on a debt-schedule. If we win the Bio-License at the Jubilee, I can buy him a permanent slot in the Highland Zones.

Gobi touches their wrist patch.

GOBI

And you think a promotion to the stars comes without a leash? Look at this patch. I'm slaved to the cargo hold. The 2013 variant is shivering, Jaca. It's realized it doesn't have a body to mimic. It's thirsty.

JACA

The ship is regulating the nutrient-flow. You don't need to be the conductor today.

GOBI

The AI doesn't know how to "conduct" a legacy. It knows how to replicate a result. There's a difference.

Gobi coughs.

GOBI (CONT'D)

The London Burger wasn't just protein; it was an apology. A three-hundred-thousand-dollar confession that we had broken the world.

(MORE)

GOBI (CONT'D)

If we serve them a "Pure-Fluid" version that doesn't have the weight of that apology, we aren't scientists. We're just caterers for a lie.

Jaca reads their tablet.

JACA

The mag-lev is entering the launch-shroud. Sixty minutes until we dock at the Orbital Garden. The CEO just sent a final briefing.

GOBI

Let me guess: "Keep it light. Keep it Meatless. Don't mention the heartbeats."

JACA

"Ensure the harvest reflects the serenity of the New Era."

A soft, harmonic chime. The floor begins to tilt upward as the mag-lev enters the launch-shroud. The lush green of Earth begins to shrink through the window, replaced by the brilliant, hopeful light of the void.

The G-force pushes them back into the seat.

GOBI

They want serenity? Look out that window, Jaca. That's a billion-units view of peace we had to fight for. The serenity is in the memory of the struggle.

Jaca clutches at the tablet, watching the Earth shrink.

JACA

Then why does it feel like a weight? I spent my life trying to make the world lighter, Gobi. I don't want the struggle. I want the security. I want my father to breathe clean air without a corporate tether attached to his lungs.

GOBI

You can't have one without the other. You can't have a world without a heart attack without remembering the cost of a heartbeat. That's why we're taking the Jubilee to the stars.

JACA

To the Orbital Garden. They say the air up there... they say it smells like rain on a 20th-century summer day.

GOBI

They got that part right. They say they captured the essence of the Earth's first breath after the Last Smog. A brilliant piece of engineering.

JACA

We're almost at the dock. Sixty minutes until we transition to the station. Are you stable?

GOBI

I'm stable. I'm Gobi-spec.

Gobi reaches out, touching Jaca's hand. The wrist-patch pulses a golden light that synchronizes with Jaca's pulse.

GOBI (CONT'D)

We're a dual-core, Jaca. We can hold the weight.

JACA

Together?

GOBI

Together. For the forest.

A harmonic chime. The G-force pushes them back into their seats as the mag-lev accelerates into the docking shroud. The lush green of Earth is completely gone, replaced by the brilliant, hopeful light of the sun and the vast black of the void.

The harmonic chime deepens into a resonant, rhythmic thrum. Through the panoramic windows, the stars are no longer distant pinpricks; they are unblinking eyes watching the shuttle dock.

Jaca unstraps their safety harness as the G-force subsides.

JACA

We're at zero-G. Transition in five minutes.

Gobi checks the wrist patch, which now glows.

GOBI

The 2013-spec has stilled. It likes the Meatlessness, Jaca. It's finally found its form. It's not a cloud anymore; it's a monument.

Jaca looks out at the approaching station with its rotating wheel of silver and green.

JACA

The Orbital Garden. It looks exactly like the archival renders. I spent six months coding the sunlight-diffusion for this sector. I never thought I'd actually breathe the air.

GOBI

Don't just breathe it. Feel it. We're about to serve a heartbeat to a station that was built to forget they exist.

Jaca picks up their tablet, and takes a deep breath.

JACA

The CEO's proxy is waiting at the airlock. Remember: we are the face of the New Era. Professional. Visionary.

GOBI

And hungry. Don't forget that part. If they aren't hungry for the truth, they'll never swallow the meal.

A hiss as the shuttle docks. The mag-lev doors slide open, revealing a lush corridor where the scent is of a summer rain. Jaca and Gobi step out together, their silhouettes framed by the blue light of the Earth below.

Black out.

SCENE 2

THE ORBITAL GARDEN

July 2063.

It is a high-tech conservatory. Translucent walls reveal the stars, and the floor is bioluminescent moss. In the center, a sleek Bioreactor XY sits like a sculpture. Jaca meticulously prunes lab-grown tomatoes, while Gobi, tethered to the vat by a wire, sits peacefully but appears thin.

JACA

(to the audience)

Day fifteen. The Great Peace follows us even here. In the foundry on Earth, the silence was heavy, like a warning. Here, it's a blanket. The CEO calls this the "Incubation of Peace." They want the Golden Burger to absorb the literal atmosphere of the Garden. They think if the meat breathes the scent of rain, it will forget it ever needed a bone. But Gobi... Gobi isn't forgetting.

(to Gobi)

Gobi? You okay?

GOBI

(With eyes closed)

It's not a shiver today, Jaca. It's a purr.

Gobi extends their hand to a nearby bioluminescent shrub. They carefully part the leaves to reveal a lab-created HUMMINGBIRD, hovering.

GOBI (CONT'D)

They're even engineered the animals here...

JACA

Your biometric levels are dipping into the blue. You need to un-tether for an hour. Eat something real.

GOBI

If I un-tether, the purr stops.

Jaca kneels beside Gobi, reaching for the sensor patch.

GOBI (CONT'D)

No... Leave it.

JACA

It's a burn, Gobi. A literal burn in your arm.

Jaca gestures to a small, sleek refrigerator unit in the wall.

JACA (CONT'D) (CONT'D)

Look. I saved some real Earth-grown protein from the flight. It's not much, just a small piece of processed pork. But it has protein, nutrients we need.

GOBI

Pork? Where's the bone?

JACA

There is no bone! It's just meat, Gobi. Fuel. Energy. You look terrible. You're giving the meat a heartbeat, but you're forgetting your own.

GOBI

The heart needs a purpose, Jaca. Not just protein.

Jaca retrieves a small, vacuum-sealed package and unwraps a pale, processed-looking piece of meat. They offer it to Gobi, who shakes their head.

GOBI (CONT'D)

I can't. It feels... heavy in a way I'm not used to anymore. A different kind of heavy than the meat in the vat.

Gobi winces as the burn in their arm flares red.

JACA

You need the friction of a real meal, Gobi, not just the abstract friction of a memory.

Gobi looks at the raw protein in Jaca's hand, then back at the humming Bioreactor.

GOBI

The friction is in the work, Jaca. The computer keeps it alive, but it can't keep it curious.

Jaca pulls a small, sterile patch from their pocket and works to adjust Gobi's existing sensor.

JACA

The answer is 1.0 density and a perfect sear.
That's what the Bio-License requires. Not...
not pain.

GOBI

No pain, no rain.

JACA

I smell it. It's the rain from the Great
Wilding of '44. It's supposed to trigger a
release of oxytocin in the viewers.

GOBI

Ha! Oxytocin. Optimization. We've turned the
weather into a sedative. I remember when rain
smelled like wet pavement and desperation. I
remember when it meant the harvest might fail.
There was a stakes to the scent back then.

JACA

Stakes are just another word for instability.
Why do you miss the anxiety of the Blood Era?
My father spent forty years breathing through a
charcoal filter because the stakes were too
high.

GOBI

I don't miss the blood, kid. I miss the choice.
In the Garden, everything is decided by an
algorithm designed to keep our heart rates at a
steady sixty beats per minute. Even this
burger... the CEO wants it to be a "Harmonic
Nutrient." They want people to eat it and
feel... nothing. Just a quiet fullness.

Jaca checks Gobi's pulse.

JACA

And what do you want them to feel?

GOBI

I want them to feel the 2013 spec. I want them
to feel the moment we stood in that London lab
and realized we could change the destiny of the
planet. I want them to feel the work.

Gobi winces as the umbilical wire
pulses a neon gold.

GOBI (CONT'D)

If they don't feel the work, they'll never
value the peace.

JACA

Your pulse is at eighty-five. You're fighting the Garden's rhythm.

GOBI

I'm providing the friction, Jaca. Without friction, the meat is just... a cloud.

Gobi looks out at the rotating Earth.

GOBI (CONT'D)

We're days out from the Jubilee. The CEO is already planning the global victory feast. They've invited the Wilding Ministers from four continents.

JACA

They're calling it the Feast of Mercy.

GOBI

Mercy is a heavy word with no backbone.

Kneeling beside Gobi, Jaca's hand hovers over the umbilical wire.

JACA

The CEO sent a data-push while you were under. They've rebranded the 2013 London Burger as "The Harmonic Disc." They've stripped your name from the technical specifications, Gobi. They're calling the biometric link a "Standardized Biosync."

GOBI

Standardized. Like a heartbeat is just a line of code you can copy and paste. They want the "Sync," but they don't want the "Bio."

JACA

They're terrified the world will find out that the meat still needs a person. They want to sell the idea that the Garden grows itself. If they admit that the 2013-spec only holds its density because you're bleeding your adrenaline into the nutrient-mix, the "Meatless" dream collapses.

Gobi opens their eyes and looks directly at Jaca.

GOBI

The dream isn't collapsing, kid. It's just finally waking up.

Gobi winces as the wire pulses a deep, rhythmic amber.

GOBI (CONT'D)

My father used to say that you don't own a piece of land until you've bled into the dirt. I guess the same goes for the future.

Jaca touches the warm glass of the bioreactor.

JACA

It's heavy today. The density is 1.1. That's higher than the 2013 record. Gobi... it's not just mimicking a heart. It's trying to be one.

GOBI

That's because it's finally listening. For forty years, we told the cells to be "Pure-Fluid." We told them to be nothing. Now, for the first time, someone is telling them to be... persistent.

JACA

My father called me this morning. He said the air in the Highland Zones is so clear it hurts his lungs. He doesn't know about the link, Gobi. He thinks I'm winning a Bio-License on my own merit.

GOBI

You are winning it. You're the one keeping the CEO from seeing the link. You're the architect of the lie that lets the truth grow.

Gobi reaches out, their hand trembling, and touches Jaca's wrist.

GOBI (CONT'D)

But you're starting to shiver too, Marrow Designer.

Jaca's hand trembles in sync with Gobi.

JACA

It's just the oscillation of the station. The centrifugal force—

GOBI

It's not the station, Jaca. It's the handshake. The vat isn't just taking my rhythm anymore;

(MORE)

GOBI (CONT'D)

it's looking for a secondary core. It's looking for you.

JACA

I am the Marrow Designer. I am the observer. I don't link. If the CEO sees a dual-biometric signature on the Jubilee feed, we don't just lose the license. They'll "Recycle" the entire station. They'll claim the Garden was contaminated by Unregulated Human Interference.

GOBI

They already think we're interference. That's why they put us in a cage made of glass and lavender. The 2013-spec is hitting critical mass. It's becoming too dense for the acoustic levitators to hold. It's starting to drop, Jaca.

Jaca frantically swipe at the tablet.

JACA

I can increase the frequency. I can boost the magnets—

GOBI

You can't boost gravity. The meat wants to be heavy. It wants to hit the plate with a beat that the world can hear. If you keep it "Meatless," you're just serving them another soap bubble.

JACA

(Turning on Gobi, fierce)

A soap bubble keeps my father breathing! A soap bubble is the reason we don't have to kill anything! Why are you so obsessed with the "Beat"?

GOBI

Because the "Beat" is the only thing that proves we were here.

Gobi reaches for the umbilical wire, their fingers hovering over the release valve.

GOBI (CONT'D)

We're a week from High Noon. The CEO is already prepping the Global Reset protocols. They want a clean harvest, Jaca. A silent one.

Jaca steps towards the bioreactor.

JACA

Then let it be silent. Let it be perfect.
Just... let us survive it.

A low-frequency hum vibrates
through the mossy floor. The
Bioreactor flares with a sudden,
violent amber light.

JACA (CONT'D)

The acoustic fields are buckling! Gobi, the
density is at 1.5. It's over-calcifying. The
cells... they aren't just mimicking the 2013-
spec, they're fossilizing.

GOBI

It's not fossilizing. It's... anchoring. It's
trying to find a center of gravity in a room
that was built to deny it. Jaca, the CEO is
spiking the levitation frequencies. They're
trying to force it back into a cloud.

JACA

I'm seeing a data-collision! The CEO is
flooding the nutrient valves with soy-
stabilizers—they're trying to mask your
biometric signature before the World Food
Summit sensors lock on. They want a clean
product, Gobi! A silent product!

GOBI

Contaminate? I'm the only thing in this tank
that isn't a lie! You want a Meatless burger?
Then why does the world feel so heavy, Boss?

The mossy floor begins to pulse
with a violent, rhythmic red
light. The harmonic chime of the
station is replaced by a jagged,
high-pitched acoustic alarm.

Jaca checks Gobi's vitals. They
are redlining.

JACA

Gobi, stop. Your blood pressure is hitting the
stroke-zone. The wire... it's glowing, Gobi.
It's pulling more than just your pulse— YOUR
HEAT. You're becoming the oven!

GOBI

Five days... Jaca. Don't let them... un-link
us.

A moment of hesitation, then a decisive movement. They rip a bundle of wires from the decorative lighting and jam them into the bioreactor's power port.

JACA

I'm slaving the station's main oxygen-scrubbers to the vat's cooling system. If the CEO tries to purge you, they'll have to suffocate the whole Orbital Garden to do it.

GOBI

Now that's... some aggressive architecture.

JACA

(to the jumbotron)

They're cutting the feeds. They're trying to segment the broadcast so the colonies only see a scenesimulation. Gobi, they're erasing the struggle in real-time!

GOBI

Let them segment the data. They can't segment the vibration. Jaca... link in. Not for the license. Not for the air. For the truth.

JACA

If I link, I can't hide the signature anymore. We'll be two ghosts screaming into a vacuum.

GOBI

But the world will hear the harmony. For forty years, they've lived in a Great Peace that was built on a whisper. Let's give them a shout.

Jaca looks at the tablet. A notification flashes: OXYGEN DEBT CLEARED. WELCOME TO THE HIGHLAND ZONES. Jaca stares at it for a beat, then with a jagged, defiant motion, they swipe the notification into the trash. They rip open their sleeve and slap the secondary sensor onto their forearm.

JACA

God... it's... it's heavy.

GOBI

That's how you know... it's real.

A resonant BEAT vibrates the floorplates as the two heartbeats synchronize. The Bioreactor flares with a brilliant, unified amber light that overpowers the Garden's clinical glow. The Jumbotron timer snaps to 10:00.

ANNOUNCER (V.O.)

Ten minutes to harvest! Diez minutos! The world food summit is tuned to the orbital garden! Citizens, are you ready to feel the future?

Jaca and Gobi stand silhouetted against the blinding light of the Sun, two cultivators tethered to a piece of meat that is finally starting to beat.

Black out.

END OF ACT II

ACT III: THE PAST MOLDSCENE 1

LONDON KITCHEN

2013.

The stage is a dimly lit lab bench in an old-world laboratory. A much younger Gobi, late teens, is focused on a bioreactor with an old-time burger. Gobi's superior, known simply as MENTOR, oversees from a monitor.

YOUNG GOBI

(to the audience)

2013. They say this is the future. A three-hundred-thousand-euro confession. We call it the London Burger. It's protein, grown from a single cell. No kill. No blood. No beat. The world is holding its breath. We have one shot to change everything. One bite to create a merciful world.

(to Mentor)

This better be a something burger and not a nothing burger.

MENTOR (V.O.)

It will work, Gobi. The media event is booked for August 5th. Sergey Brin is expecting a burger, not a scientific apology. We're addressing global food security, not your existential dread.

Gobi cooks.

MENTOR (V.O.)

The color, Gobi. It's too white. We need myoglobin, or the chef will have nothing to fry. Add the beetroot juice and saffron mix.

YOUNG GOBI

It'll taste like dirt and a spice rack. Not meat.

MENTOR (V.O.)

Add the colorants. We need it to look like a burger. Perception is half the grant money.

Gobi sighs, adding the mix. The liquid in the vat turns an unnatural red.

MENTOR (V.O.)

Gobi, the temperature gauge on the main incubator is spiking. We're losing two years of cell lines!

YOUNG GOBI

Vent the oxygen! Siphon the nutrient mix! We can't lose the samples. We're so close!

Gobi works frantically to save the culture.

SCENE 2

APARTMENT

August 4, 2013. 3AM.

The only light comes from the streetlights filtering through a window and the LED of a tablet on a desk.

Gobi, wearing a t-shirt and sweats, sits at the desk. They are staring at the tablet, which displays complex cell culture data and a diagram of the lab's bioreactor.

YOUNG GOBI

The silence is deafening. In the lab, it's just the hum of the machines and the quiet fizz of the nutrient mix. No lowing. No feathers ruffling. Just... clean, clinical silence.

Gobi swipes the tablet, a schematic of the lab burger filling the display.

YOUNG GOBI (CONT'D)

"No kill." "Mercy with every bite." That's the slogan. But is it mercy if you just erase the memory of what was lost? If you pretend the whole thing never had a heartbeat to begin with?

They lean back in their chair, rubbing their eyes. They look deeply unsettled.

YOUNG GOBI (CONT'D)

I love farms. Since I was a kid. The smell of the dirt, the sound of the cattle... heavy. Real. This burger... it's just a line of code. A beautiful, delicious lie that was built on a terror we're all too happy to forget.

Gobi gets up and paces the small room, their bare feet silent on the floor.

YOUNG GOBI (CONT'D)

They want me to add colorant so it "looks" real. So it can be a brand. A brand isn't a heartbeat. A brand is just an absence of something else.

Gobi stops at the window, looking out at the sterile city below. They make a decision.

YOUNG GOBI (CONT'D)

I need to see the cost. I need to remember the weight before it's a cloud.

Gobi moves quickly, grabbing their sketchbook and pulling on their shoes. They open the door.

SCENE 3

LONDON STREET

August 4, 2013. Mid-afternoon.

The street is busy, a mix of modern architecture and older, slightly run-down buildings. SOUND of moderate city traffic, distant chatter.

Gobi, in casual clothes, walks with purpose, a sketchbook in hand. They look stressed, preoccupied.

They stop outside a small, old-fashioned BUTCHER SHOP. The window is cluttered with meat displays and hand-written signs.

YOUNG GOBI

(to the audience)

I needed to see something real.

(MORE)

YOUNG GOBI (CONT'D)

The lab felt like a tomb. Clean, quiet, and dead. They wanted a miracle, but miracles are messy, aren't they? They leave scars.

Gobi stares intently at a small, framed photograph taped next to a price list in the shop window. It's a simple picture of a COW standing in a field.

A BUTCHER exits the shop, wiping their hands on a stained apron. They notice Gobi staring at the photo.

BUTCHER

Something I can help you with? That picture's not for sale. Belonged to my granddad.

YOUNG GOBI

Oh. No. Just... the cow.

BUTCHER

A fine animal. Before the big farms took over everything. They had a heartbeat, you know.

YOUNG GOBI

A beat.

BUTCHER

Yeah. My granddad always said if you can't feel the weight of what you're eating, you don't value the meal. People forget that. They want it easy.

YOUNG GOBI

They want to forget the terror.

BUTCHER

(squinting)

Maybe. Or maybe they just want a burger without feeling guilty. This one wasn't about guilt. It was about respect.

The Butcher rips the photograph off the window and offers it to Gobi.

BUTCHER (CONT'D)

You look like you need it more than I do. The future's coming, they say. I hear we won't need butchers soon.

YOUNG GOBI

Thanks.

BUTCHER

Don't mention it. Good luck with... whatever
you're doing.

The Butcher goes inside. Gobi
stands alone on the street,
holding the picture. They clench
it in their fist, the paper
crinkling slightly. The distant
city noise fades, replaced by the
faint sound of a heartbeat.

YOUNG GOBI

I will spend the rest of my life making sure
the miracle has a backbone.

Gobi places the photo carefully in
their pocket and walks off, a
determined look on their face.

Black out.

SCENE 4

LONDON STUDIO

August 5, 2013. Noon.

The space is a cramped, messy
backstage lab area, dimly lit by a
single utilitarian light. A TV
monitor flickers silently in the
background, showing the brightly
lit stage of the tasting event,
currently empty.

Gobi is alone. They hold a stringy
piece of the lab-grown meat. They
stare at it intently, turning it
over in their hands.

GOBI

(to the audience)

They want a miracle. The world is holding its
breath for a miracle on a bun.

They bring the piece of protein
close to their ear, listening to
it.

GOBI (CONT'D)

But it's silent. No life. No heart. A clean, clinical absence of a beat. We did it. We stopped the killing.

They look up at the silent monitor, where an announcer is gesticulating, though we cannot hear the sound.

GOBI (CONT'D)

And what was the cost? We traded the slaughterhouse for the foundry, and the Earth breathed back. But a world without hunger is a world that forgets. They'll eat this, and they'll feel... nothing. Just a quiet fullness, built on a lie that it was easy.

They clench the protein in their fist, with a pained expression.

GOBI (CONT'D)

I wanted mercy. I wanted the promise. But a promise without friction is just a dream. This... this is just a cloud. I will spend the rest of my life making sure the miracle has a backbone. Even if I have to break the machine to do it.

A frantic voice is heard from MENTOR.

MENTOR (V.O.)

Gobi! They're waiting! Bring the sample!

Gobi looks at the door, then back at the protein in their hand. They opens their hand and gently places the muscle strands onto a plate. They pick up the plate, taking one last look at the silent monitor.

GOBI

The truth needs a heartbeat.

They exit. The screen suddenly snaps to a close-up of the burger.

SCENE 5

LONDON STUDIO

August 5, 2013. Evening.

The room is dark. Gobi sits on a crate, staring at a photograph in their hand. Their phone rings. They answer.

MENTOR (V.O.)

I thought you went home. The metrics are good, Gobi. The press is calling it a "culinary leap forward."

GOBI

(Bitterly)

"Clean meat." They also called it an "animal-protein cake." We did it, though. We fed the world an absence of guilt.

MENTOR (V.O.)

It's a brand, Gobi. A brand is how you change the world. This technology eliminates slaughter. That is the greatest act of mercy in human history.

GOBI

Mercy is a heavy word with no backbone. They want the feeling, but they don't want the memory of its risks...

MENTOR (V.O.)

I know the story. You felt the weight. That feeling is why we are here, Gobi. To ensure no one else has to feel it. Now, go home. The design on the Foundry starts tomorrow.

GOBI

We're going to build the Cloud. Fine. But the next time we do this, the world is going to feel something real. Pain is the only thing that makes it real.

MENTOR (V.O.)

It will feel full, Gobi. That's enough.

Gobi hangs up the phone without another word. They look at the photograph, then put it into his pocket. A look of quiet, dangerous resolve settles on their face.

GOBI

(to the audience)

To be frank... They just want us to forget. Forget that beat sound when something real becomes your dinner.

(MORE)

GOBI (CONT'D)

They want this quiet world where everything's all clean and nothing ever has to die just so it can taste good. A world without that weight? It's a flimsy dream.

I remember the smell of the grill that night. The juice. It just felt like this big lie, built on actual terror. So I made this thing to forget that terror. But if you forget the terror, you forget the value. You forget the heartbeat.

This new meat... I mean, it's a cool science experiment and all, but it has no soul. It has no history to, like, chew on. It's just... nothing. I'm not gonna let that be the legacy. No way. The world needs to hear the impact. The world needs to remember where food comes from. They need to know what a meal actually costs.

I am the future, I guess, and the future needs a spine.

Black out.

SCENE 6

THE LIBRARY ARCHIVE

2053.

The library observation deck is quiet, just the low hum of the clean air system. 14-year-old Jaca is totally sucked into a giant screen, flicking through old data about the planet.

YOUNG JACA

Okay, so the air is chill. Methane? Gone. Water systems are all perfect now. Sweet.

Jaca swipes the screen, pulling up some really old, messy footage of a place that used to farm animals. The pictures are all crazy and chaotic. Jaca just keeps watching, looking all clinical.

YOUNG JACA (CONT'D)

Seriously? Look at this mess. They called it The Blood Era. Talk about an absolute dumpster fire. People just went with this madness? Wild.

Jaca swipes again, bringing up text data on an "Oxygen Audit." A red line flashes: "DEBT OWED: 3 MONTHS."

YOUNG JACA (CONT'D)

Wild isn't having to think about the air you breathe every second.

Jaca minimizes the audit screen, the red light still a reflection in their eyes. They go back to the archival footage of a farm. A cow moos, the sound loud in the silent library. Jaca stares at the screen, a tremor starting in their hands. They lean closer to the screen, the sound of the animal an unwelcome weight in the quiet room.

YOUNG JACA (CONT'D)

My dad's lungs hurt. He coughs all day, every day. He works in the Mid-Zones. He can't afford the clean air up here in the Highland Zones... this is why we built the world like this, isn't it? To make the noise stop. To make the fear go away.

Jaca watches as a silhouette of a person approaches the cow on the screen. The footage is blurry, but the implication is clear. Jaca flinches, swiping the screen violently to a blank, white corporate logo.

YOUNG GOBI

It wasn't just the meat. It was the air. The water. The noise. The weight of it all. Gobi misses the weight... but the weight is what keeps my dad tethered to a machine.

A holographic librarian figure glides nearby or is on screen.

LIBRARIAN (V.O.)

Everything alright, Jaca? The Blood Era archives can be... intense. They say the air on the ground used to hurt your lungs back then.

YOUNG JACA

My dad lives in the Mid-Zones. His oxygen debt is three months overdue. He breathes a... discounted atmosphere.

LIBRARIAN (V.O.)

Oh. I'm sorry to hear that. The system isn't seamless for everyone yet, I know. But we're getting there. Can I assist with your analysis of the Great Peace architecture?

YOUNG JACA

The Cloud Protein license is our ticket to a better world, right? No more mess. No more... terror.

LIBRARIAN (V.O.)

No more a heartbeat you can't ignore.

Jaca pulls up an article from Dr. Gobi.

YOUNG JACA

"Mercy is a heavy word with no backbone." What even is that? That's some serious corporate mumbo-jumbo, trying to make peace sound bad.

LIBRARIAN (V.O.)

Outdated philosophy, Jaca. Modern behavioral science indicates that the absence of anxiety is a primary component of a happy and productive life. The current system ensures security over struggle.

Jaca nods, seriously. They start dragging the old, messy history into a folder called "Garbage."

YOUNG JACA

Security is everything. The past was a total fail. The struggle isn't deep; it's just a broken system they finally fixed. That old way is totally canceled.

Jaca finishes organizing, adding a new label to the "Biometric Syncing" file: "Vibes"

YOUNG JACA (CONT'D)

My dad can breathe easy because of this new world. I need to keep it that way. No drama, just good tech and clear air. All that other stuff? It's just background noise.

Jaca minimizes the history files
and starts a fresh design for some
food garden in space. They look
out the window at the peaceful
planet below.

YOUNG JACA (CONT'D)

I'm not here for some deep life lesson. I'm
here for a secure system. The future is clean,
quiet, and totally lit.

Black out.

END OF ACT III

ACT IV: THE BURGER JUBILEE

THE ORBITAL FOUNDRY

August 5, 2063.

The Gravity-Well Grill. A cramped, semi-legal food stand attached to the outer hull of the Orbital Foundry. The space is a claustrophobic mess of hanging wires, dented counters, and a flickering neon sign that reads: Boneless (Mercy with Every Bite).

The Earth is outside. The stage vibrates with the roar of the exhaust vents. Bioreactor XY has been replaced by a battered, transparent vat sitting on a grease-stained counter.

The Jumbotron snaps to a massive countdown timer visible to the planet: 21:00.

A split stage. Two isolated pools of light. Jaca is manically wiping down a tray of grease. They are wearing a frayed corporate uniform. Gobi is slumped on a crate behind the counter. A glowing blue umbilical wire leads from a sensor on their chest into the vat. They are drinking from a pouch.

JACA

(to the audience)

Welcome to the Gravity Well! Five billion views and counting! We aren't just serving a normal burger today, but the 2013 London! The beginning of the No Kill Era. Come for the Cloud, stay for the Mercy.

GOBI

(to the audience)

Five billion souls watching a food stand. They want a sensational story, not history. Six weeks I've spent as a human battery for this grease-trap. The machine is thirsty, and my rhythm is the only currency that hasn't devalued.

(MORE)

GOBI (CONT'D)

Jaca thinks they're the driver of a global movement, but they're just flipping ghosts in a zero-G frying pan...

A blinding glare of sunlight hits the station. A bass drop.

ANNOUNCER (V.O.)

Citizens of Earth! ¡Ciudadanos de la tierra!

Wananchi wa dunia! 地球上的公民们

The wait is over! From the Andes to the Arctic, five billion souls are logged in! Twenty minutes until the High Noon harvest at the Gravity-Well!

黄金周年大賽即將開始! Jubilee inaanza hivi karibuni! La competición comienza pronto!

A rhythmic ping echoes. A scrolling red text appears on a cracked monitor: Message from CEO: PRIMARY ASSET STABILIZATION REQUIRED. DO NOT FAIL THE BRAND. Jaca frantically checks the monitor.

JACA

Gobi, the CEO is in the feed. They say if the density isn't a perfect 1.0 when the clock hits twelve, they'll initiate a *Global Reset*. They'll shut our oxygen-scrubbers and let the world watch us drift.

Gobi leans against the greasy vat.

GOBI

Let them shut the air. Tell them the world didn't tune in for a sanitized product. They tuned in to see if the "Cloud" has a heartbeat.

JACA

Your heart rate is 120. We're twenty minutes out. If we don't un-tether you by the time the competition starts, the acoustic fields will invert. You'll be seared into the burger before the first customer bites.

Gobi holds a metal spatula.

GOBI

Then at least it'll be a meal the world finally feels.

The timer on the cracked monitor hits 15:00. A violent shudder rocks the stand, the Foundry's docking clamps engaging. Outside, a massive cargo ship occludes the sun, plunging the stand into a strobing, industrial indigo.

JACA

The density is hitting 1.5! Gobi, the CEO is spiking the levitation frequencies from the command deck. They're trying to force a Standardized Disc shape. They want a flat, stackable, corporate-approved circle. They're trying to crush your rhythm!

GOBI

Tell them... tell them a heart doesn't have a standard shape! I'm pushing back!

(to the vat)

Hold, you bastard. Hold.

Jaca frantically swipes at the flickering monitor.

JACA

I'm seeing a data-collision! The CEO is flooding the nutrient valves with soy-stabilizers. They're trying to mask your biometric signature before the judges' sensors lock on. They want a clean product, Gobi! A silent product!

The monitor flickers. The CEO echoes through the station.

CEO (V.O.)

Attention vendors. Deviation from branded geometry is a breach of contract. Stand down. Let the cloud be meatless and weightless. Do not contaminate the harvest with your individuality.

GOBI

Contaminate? I'm the only thing in this tank that isn't a lie! You want a "Weightless" burger? Then why does the world feel so heavy, Boss?

Jaca checks Gobi's vitals on a handheld.

JACA

Gobi, stop. Your blood pressure is hitting the stroke-zone. You're becoming the grill!

ANNOUNCER (V.O.)

Ten minutes to the High Noon Harvest. Des minutes jusga la recolte! Diez minutos para la cosecha! Citizens, are you ready to taste the future?!

Gobi slumps against the greasy glass, their forehead touching the warm vat.

GOBI

Ten minutes... Jaca. Don't let them... un-link us. If they kill the signal... they kill the truth.

A moment of hesitation, then a decisive movement. They rip a bundle of wires from the neon sign and jam them into the vat's power port.

JACA

I'm slaving the stand's main oxygen-scrubbers to the vat's cooling system. If the CEO tries to purge you, they'll have to suffocate the whole orbital deck to do it.

GOBI

Now that's... some aggressive street-food.

The flickering neon sign "BONELESS" surges with blinding light. The thumping of the heartbeat doubles in volume, shaking the very air in the orbital kitchen as the countdown hits the final 09:59.

GOBI (CONT'D)

Now that's... some aggressive street-food.

Jaca struggles to keep their footing as the station's vibration intensifies.

JACA

The feedback loop is tightening, Gobi! Your pulse is feeding the thermal coils. The vat is hitting five hundred degrees. If we don't vent the nitrogen, we're gonna be the first meal to supernova in low earth orbit!

GOBI

Let it burn! The 2013-spec was never about being cool. It was about the fire! It was about the day we decided to stop being predators and started being architects. Feel that? That's not a malfunction. That's the weight of the conscience hitting the grill!

ANNOUNCER (V.O.)

Eight minutes to harvest! Valo lazima! The gravity well is turning into a star! Viewership now six billion! The world is holding its breath!

Jaca frantically rewires a bypassed sensor.

JACA

The CEO is attempting a "Biometric Scrub"! They're trying to digitalize your pulse out of the broadcast signal! They want the world to see the burger, but they're trying to erase the man behind the curtain!

GOBI

They can't erase the heat, Jaca! They can't scrub the smell of a real sear!

A red alert light begins to strobe from the ceiling. A siren, low and industrial, begins to wail.

Jaca checks the monitor.

JACA

They've given up on the scrub, Gobi. They're going for a total blackout.

GOBI

What?

JACA

The CEO is initiating a "Fire Wall Purge"! They're cutting the power to the external stalls! They'd rather have us drift into the graveyard orbit than let the Judges taste a heartbeat!

The indigo light of the station is replaced by a sickly red. The hum has heavy thumps of the vat.

Gobi gasps for air as the atmospheric pressure begins to drop.

GOBI

They're... they're actually doing it. They're dumping... the oxygen.

Jaca fumbles with an emergency respirator.

JACA

It's not... about the meat or bone anymore, Gobi. It's about the... the precedent. If they let a "Heartbeat Burger" hit the feed, the whole... Cloud market... collapses. They'd rather we be... martyrs of a "technical glitch" than champions of the truth.

ANNOUNCER (V.O.)

(Distorted)

Si-si-six minutes remain. We are experiencing signal interference... from the orbital grid. Stand by, citizens! The cloud is... persisting-

Gobi clutches the side of the vat, their skin appears translucent under the red strobe.

GOBI

Look at the... the Jumbotron, Jaca. Five billion people... are watching the lights... go out. They know. They know it's not... a glitch.

Jaca tries to fit the respirator over Gobi's face.

JACA

Put this on! If you... flatline now... the levitation... it dies! The harvest... it'll be a puddle!

GOBI

No. If I... put that on... my pulse... slows down. The sear... it needs the adrenaline. It needs the... the friction.

(to the monitor)

You want to... starve us, Boss? Fine. But we're... taking the sun... with us.

Jaca looks at the 2013 London readout, which is now glowing gold.

JACA

It's... it's over-calcifying. Gobi, the bone-lattice is... it's becoming a diamond. It's too heavy for the magnets!

GOBI

Then... let it... fall.

JACA

The CEO is initiating a "Fire Wall Purge"! They're cutting the power to the external stalls! They'd rather have us drift into the graveyard orbit than let the Judges taste a heartbeat!

GOBI

Then... we give them... the weight. Jaca... bypass the acoustic leveling. Let the gravity-well take it.

JACA

If I cut the leveling, the mass will hit the grill at three Gs! It'll shatter the glass, Gobi! We're in a pressurized tube!

GOBI

Let it shatter! The world needs to hear the impact! Trust the bone! Trust the 2023-spec! Do it!

The timer hits 5:00. The sun emerges from behind a cargo ship, casting a glare that creates a halo effect with the steam. The Cloud Protein in the vat is a thick, irregular monument of seared marrow, pulsing with light.

JACA

The CEO is initiating a grilling purge! They're cutting the power to the external stalls! They'd rather have us drift into the graveyard orbit than let the Judges taste a heartbeat!

Gobi gasps, clutching the counter.

GOBI

Then... we give them... the weight. Jaca... bypass the acoustic leveling. Let the Gravity Well take it.

JACA

If I cut the leveling, the mass will hit the grill at three Gs! It'll shatter the glass, Gobi! We're in a pressurized tube!

GOBI

Let it shatter! The world needs to hear the impact! Trust the bone! Trust 2023! Do it!

Jaca slams the emergency release. A CRACK echoes as the glass of the vat shatters. Instead of drifting, this Cloud Protein drops with a visceral BEAT onto the plate. A cloud of steam fills the stand.

ANNOUNCER (V.O.)

Unexpected impact! The biomass has landed. La recolte a atterri! The harvest is... solid as a skeleton!

CEO (V.O.)

Vendors, Gobi and Jaca. Your lease has been terminated. Your assets will be purged.

Gobi slumps to the floor. Their lungs burn while laughing.

GOBI

Terminate... whatever you want. We're live... on every screen... in the sky.

JACA

We're not eye-less...

ANNOUNCER (V.O.)

It's noon! C est midi! Es mediodia! Citizens of Earth... The Gravity Well has served! The golden burger has their heartbeat!

The Jumbotron snaps to a close-up of the burger. It is charred, heavy, and leaking real, crimson-amber juice onto the dented chrome. Gobi and Jaca are silhouetted against the blinding curve of the Earth, two street-vendors who finally gave the future a spine.

JACA

They're eating it, Gobi. Look at the pings. Five billion people... just realized they're hungry.

GOBI

Let them eat. At least... they'll finally know
how a meal feels.

JACA

They'll never know that it was called a
whopper.

The flickering "BONELESS" sign
gives a triumphant spark and dies.
The lights in the stand fade to
the glow of the Earth below. Jaca
and Gobi sit in the silence of the
void, tethered to nothing but each
other.

END OF PLAY